

Helping Challenged Individuals Communicate Effectively with Open Source Tech



My work with Endosulfan-affected communities in northern Kerala led me to explore AAC tools and open source solutions that can help individuals with communication challenges express themselves more effectively.

I am from northern Kerala, and for nearly two decades I have been associated with groups working with people affected by Endosulfan exposure in Kasaragod district. Through this work, I have interacted with many individuals with Down syndrome, autism spectrum disorder, and cerebral palsy.

One thing I observed repeatedly was the challenge of communication. Many of these individuals have thoughts, emotions and needs just like everyone else, but expressing them is often difficult. This motivated me to look more closely at technologies that can help people communicate better.

Down syndrome, autism spectrum disorder and cerebral palsy are not the same. Down syndrome is a genetic

condition caused by an extra copy of chromosome 21. Autism spectrum disorder primarily affects social interaction and behaviour, although it varies widely from person to person. Cerebral palsy mainly affects movement and motor functions, and many individuals with cerebral palsy may have perfectly normal intelligence.

I remember a professor from Kasaragod who had cerebral palsy. He had completed his higher education, cleared national-level examinations and was working as a faculty member. Yet he was denied entry into an aircraft because people assumed he could not travel independently. Experiences like these remind us that we should not

judge a person's abilities based solely on appearance.

Why communication matters

Over the years, I have met many people who faced significant communication barriers. In some cases, communication becomes a bigger challenge than the condition itself.

Today, we have the resources and technology to address many of these issues. Communication is closely linked to dignity, independence and participation in society. If a person cannot communicate effectively, opportunities in education, employment and everyday life become limited.

This is where Augmentative and Alternative Communication (AAC)